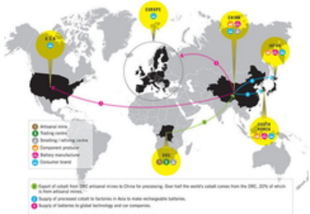
Mineral Extraction

This is a new form of colonialism. Miners carry out the invisible work behind AI. In African nations, children are being forced to work in mines to support the AI technologies we use. These individuals are not paid adequate wages, while profits are monopolized by large corporations that control the supply chains.

DRC cobalt mines

Mining cobalt, lithium, and rare earths powers batteries, phones, and chips. The supply chain often depends on exploited labor and environmental destruction. Children and adults mine cobalt in dangerous, often unregulated pits. Work can last up to 12 hours a day. Amnesty reports that around 40,000 children work in southern DRC mining areas, that miners often work long hours without protective gear, and that child labor is tied to hazardous conditions and low pay. In addition, UNICEF-linked estimates cited by Amnesty put the number of child miners in southern DRC at about 40,000.

Picture : Human Rights Watch

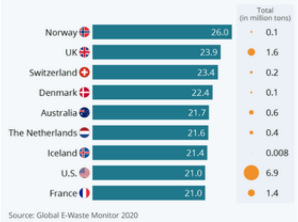


Who own?

In Chile, lithium production has been dominated by SQM and Albemarle, with greater state oversight now being negotiated. In the DRC, cobalt from artisanal mines often passes through traders and firms tied to China-based processing networks. Local communities usually bear the costs, while companies and downstream manufacturers capture most of the value.

There is a vast wage gap between workers in Congolese cobalt mines, who often earn poverty wages, and CEOs of American tech companies, whose compensation can reach hundreds or even tens of thousands of dollars per day. Furthermore, electronic devices such as iPhones—manufactured using materials like cobalt and lithium—are expensive; yet, despite the substantial profits generated by tech companies, these earnings are not reinvested in the children working at the mining sites where these resources are extracted, but are instead hoarded by the corporations.

Child labor in DR Congo	\$1–\$2.50 a day
Average salary in DR Congo	\$8 per day
Average U.S. tech CEO salary	\$399 per day
High-paid company CEOs	\$46,849 per day
Price of iPhone	\$799
Revenue of Apple	\$143.8 billion.



Countries that produce e-waste

E-waste

The colonial-style exploitation of developing nations surrounding the AI industry extends not only to the production phase but also to the disposal phase. E-waste is the world's fastest-growing domestic waste stream, with 62 million tonnes generated in 2022. Although the majority of e-waste is generated in developed nations, it is frequently exported to developing countries. However, these developing nations lack the technology to properly recycle such waste; consequently, its accumulation is giving rise to environmental problems.

Muntosh's Experience

According to Save the Children's reporting, Muntosh was about six years old when he saw his brother killed in a cobalt mine when a landslide buried him. Even after that, Muntosh kept going back to work because his family needed the money. He spent years in the mines, and only later entered a learning program to catch up on school. But the damage was already done: he said that after finding and removing a large block of cobalt, his body hurt постоянно, and the physical pain stayed with him.

picture : New York Times

The invisible work behind AI is carried out by miners, particularly in the Democratic Republic of the Congo, where cobalt is extracted under dangerous and exploitative conditions. Although AI is often presented as a clean, immaterial, and highly advanced technology, it depends on a very material foundation: metals, minerals, fuel, labor, and land. Many of the miners are adults trying to support families, but children are also part of this workforce, showing how deeply poverty and inequality shape the supply chain. These miners work long hours for very low wages to supply the minerals needed for batteries and digital technologies. The people and institutions that profit the most are usually far removed from the mines. Major tech companies, battery manufacturers, mineral traders, and other corporations at the top of the supply chain reap the greatest financial rewards, while the miners who endure the harshest conditions receive only a tiny fraction of the value they create. This creates a sharp imbalance between risk and reward. Those who face the greatest physical danger, insecurity, and environmental harm are typically the least able to influence prices, labor standards, or contracts. Meanwhile, the greatest profits accumulate in corporate headquarters, investment firms, and wealthy consumer markets, rather than in the communities where extraction takes place. Furthermore, many tech companies fail to return their profits to the people responsible for mineral extraction, instead treating them as if they were a colony. This is why some critics describe the system as a form of digital colonialism.